



Bracing for a KNOCKOUT

The final denouement in Singur and the chemical hub in Nayachar will hint at which way the political wind is blowing

After a brief lull, Kolkata's favourite gladiators are back in the arena, once again engaged in grim combat. West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya kicked off the Left Front campaign at a massive rally at the Brigade Parade Grounds in Kolkata last Sunday and in a statement aimed at provoking Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee said the Government would not return the 400 acres of land earmarked for the Singur industrial project to the so-called unwilling landowners. The doughty Banerjee has given him time till the weekend to decide what is good for his party and state or her party workers would make Singur into a no-entry zone again and break the factory fencing around the 400 acres. Bhattacharya, who reiterated industrialisation was the guiding motif of his governance and that he would not balk at anything to achieve his goal, thundered, "The land will not be returned."

However, this time the Trinamool leader is far more mature than she ever has been. On February 9, Banerjee said that she had no truck

with the BJP since 2004 and that she was not a part of NDA, thus keeping her options of an alliance with the Congress open.

In retort, she has eagerly taken up the Nayachar chemical hub issue. Shortly after the Centre gave clearance to the project and the Left Front started celebrating the victory of industrialisation, Banerjee quietly laid her ace on the table: the Nayachar hub was an environmental hazard. She is now hoping that green activists will file a suit and block work on it. She has also cleverly and tacitly mentioned that among those involved in the Nayachar project include Union Carbide of Bhopal infamy.

The people of West Bengal, of course, are waiting to see what happens in Singur, the upcoming by-elections and then finally, Nayachar. Bhattacharya, who will be tested on each of them, asked his ministers to speed up all ongoing works. Banerjee, meanwhile, is waiting for the Government to take that one false step. Caught in the middle are the ordinary citizens in a crisis not of their making.

by Abhijit Dasgupta

BANERJEE (RIGHT) HAS GIVEN BHATTACHARYA THE WEEKEND TO DECIDE ON SINGUR LAND

PCPA leader Mahato says. The whole Jangalmahal area, he says, has not seen much development. "It has only two higher secondary and one Madhyamik level schools. Even the government-run health centre is also not adequate."

Mahato, however, is wary of the politicians getting mileage of their agitation. "Many political leaders are coming to show their support. I respect them. But this is our struggle and we will fight it. We will not let any political party take advantage and benefit from our struggle," Mahato says. Unlike Bimal Gurung in the hill areas, the PCPA has no plans to demand a separate state. "Gurung's support is heartening but I may not agree with his demand for a separate state. Even JMM leader Shibu Soren had approached us and had hinted that we join a call to be part of Jharkhand. We want to be part of West Bengal."

With the general elections fast approaching, the Left Front seems to be in a spot. The police excesses in Nandigram led to their defeat during the last Panchayat polls which makes it imperative for them to resolve the Lalgah agitation. The fact that the Government said the Maoists were creating all the trouble in Lalgah from November onwards has also upset the locals as well as the Opposition. Lalgah may just have added enough fuel to ensure that flame ignited in Nandigram keeps burning for a long time to come. ■